

East meets West

It was with some shock that Takemitsu recognized his own Japanese cultural identity in the 1960s, and realized its relationship with his essentially Western aesthetic ideals. He began to introduce traditional Japanese instruments into works such as *November Steps* (1967), but also found that modern indeterminate procedures of composition were compatible with traditional Japanese performance techniques, allowing for a degree of improvisation and expressive interpretation. He also discovered that the timbres and inflections of the Japanese instruments fitted well with his Debussy-inspired sound-world.



TRADITIONAL JAPANESE BAMBOO FLUTE

Throughout his teens, Tōru Takemitsu had little or no contact with Western music, which was outlawed in Japan. He was born in Tokyo in 1930, but when he was only a few weeks old his family moved to Dalian, in Japanese-occupied Manchuria. He returned to Japan in 1938 to go to school, but was unable to complete his studies as he was conscripted at the age of 14 in anticipation of a US invasion—an experience he bitterly resented.

Rebelling against the Japanese establishment, Takemitsu and his friends listened clandestinely to a gramophone record of the French popular song “Parlez-moi d’amour,” which he cited as a formative influence. After World War II, he worked for the US occupying forces, but his fragile health meant he spent prolonged periods in hospital, where he listened to American Forces Radio and developed a taste for Western music. Aged just 16, he decided to become a musician, even though he had no musical training. Apart from a few lessons with the composer Yasuji Kiyose in 1948, Takemitsu’s skills as a composer were self-